



THE MET

03.16-06.03.2027

ENDANGERED LANGUAGES

ENDANGERED TRADITIONS

LIVING LANGUAGES TRADITIONS

LANGUAGES

TRADITIONS

LIVING TRACES

gathers languages and traditions that still breathe, even as many stand at the edge of disappearance. Across oceans, deserts, forests, mountains, and ice, communities continue to sing, weave, heal, dive, carve, remember, and speak words that cannot be replaced.

This pamphlet shines light on a few of the many living inheritances that will form part of the exhibition. What you will see here are eight intangible heritages: four endangered languages and four fragile cultural practices, each carrying memory, knowledge, and identity across generations.

The exhibition will be active at The Met from March 16 to June 3, 2027. We invite you to encounter heritage not as something that is finished or distant, but as something human, vulnerable, and still being kept alive by many and by few.



ENDANGERED LANGUAGES

LANGUAGES

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AINU

Location: Japan, Hokkaido

Once suppressed through assimilation policies, Ainu survives through song, ritual, and renewed teaching. Its vocabulary encodes relationships between people, animals, and spirits. Today, community-led schools and performances restore its presence, not as a relic, but as a living voice reclaiming identity, land, and continuity across generations.



NORTHERN SAMI

Location: Norway, Sweden, Finland

Sámi languages articulate a deep ecological knowledge shaped by Arctic life. Terms for snow, migration, and reindeer herding reflect centuries of adaptation. Colonial policies once suppressed its use. Today, revitalization through education, media, and governance reconnects language with land and Indigenous presence.



RAPA NUI

Location: Rapa Nui, Chile

Spoken on one of the most remote inhabited islands, Rapa Nui carries ancestral memory tied to land and ocean. Pressures from tourism and Spanish dominance have weakened transmission. Revival efforts center on schools and storytelling, ensuring that the language continues to anchor identity within a rapidly changing culture.



JU/'HOANSI

Location: Namibia / Botswana

Ju!'hoansi is rooted in one of the world's oldest continuous cultures. Its click-based phonetics carry knowledge of tracking, plants, and survival. As modernization shifts lifestyles, transmission weakens. Documentation and community storytelling sustain it, preserving a language inseparable from the rhythms of Kalahari human history.

**AINU
TERM**

Irankarapote

“Hello, allow me to touch your heart.”

**RAPA NUI
TERM**

Beccoy

“How are you?”

LANGUAGES

**NORTHERN SAMI
TERM**

Ollu lihkku

“Congratulations!”

**JUJ’HOANSI
TERM**

!Kun!kógù

“Please speak to me.”



BIGWALA

Location: Uganda

Bigwala is a royal music tradition performed with gourd trumpets during ceremonies of the Busoga Kingdom. Once central to cultural identity, it now faces decline due to reduced patronage and aging practitioners. Safeguarding efforts focus on transmission, ensuring that its powerful sound continues to resonate across generations.



SANKE MON

Location: Mali

Sanké Mon is a communal fishing ritual marking seasonal cycles and social unity. Thousands gather in coordinated action, blending ecology, spirituality, and celebration. Environmental pressures and social change threaten its continuity, making safeguarding essential to preserving both the practice and its connection to identity.



JEJU HAENYEO

Location: South Korea

Haenyeo are women divers who harvest seafood without oxygen tanks, relying on breath, skill, and environmental knowledge. Aging practitioners and modernization threaten continuity. Their practice embodies resilience, community, and sustainable interaction with the ocean, making its preservation both cultural and ecological.



NOKEN WEAVING

Location: Papua, Indonesia

Noken bags are hand-knotted from natural fibers and used for daily life, ceremony, and symbolic exchange. Their production embodies community identity and knowledge. Industrial alternatives and shifting lifestyles threaten their use, making revitalization essential to sustaining both craft and cultural meaning.

I AM BECAUSE
WE ARE.



What remains when a language falls silent,
or a tradition is no longer practiced?

Not only words or gestures are lost, but
entire ways of understanding the world.
These living traces carry memory, identity,
and knowledge shaped over centuries.
They hold ways of seeing time, land, com-
munity, and spirit that cannot be repli-
cated once gone.

Yet this is not a narrative of disappearance
alone. Across continents, communities are
choosing to remember, to teach, to speak,
to make, and to continue. Preservation is
not passive. It is an act of will. It is the
commitment to continuous support in
the face of change.

Living Traces is a push forward to recog-
nize that heritage is not distant or static.
It exists now, carried by people whose
voices and practices remain necessary.
Their work asks something of us: to listen
more intently, to value what is fragile, and
to understand that cultural diversity is not
ornamental, but required and essential.

The future of these languages and tradi-
tions is not guaranteed. It depends on
awareness, respect, and participation.
We leave you with a final thought, con-
sider what it means to keep something
alive. Not preserved behind glass, but
practiced, spoken, and shared.

